

How to Say Tomorrow

She's slanted sparrow eyes. She's thin fingers with too many rings. She's a blue sundress on a hot day. She's walking away and I can't tell if I'm staring.

The last of her turns a corner and disappears behind the green awnings of a cafe. A wind blows over the beach, several umbrellas unearthed and spinning down the sand, children ducking, parents chasing. On the water a bell buoy rings for three large swells. I head into the city, my head down between shop windows, fixed on the stone, reliving the morning in my head. Stairs leading down into the subway. The breeze stops and I'm left with an old hot air and a certain kind of wetness.

The train comes, washing out the old heat with one that's older and hotter, the smell of grease, several people deboard. I walk on. The car is mostly empty save for a woman, her child, and a man with his suit coat slung over an arm, sweat diffusing past his ribs, his tie off and bunched up in a fist. The woman's eyes are closed with a hand tight around her son's, who's looking up at me. I take my seat.

A gear snaps and the train lurches, gathering its weight before clicking over the tracks. We snake through the tunnels under the city before rising up between carved rock and grass fields, trees in bloom, a sky blue, and strung clouds, and rolling hills lush with the end of spring. I turn out the window and watch the wind blow the trees both ways.

My stop is a station between the low slope of a mountain and a stretch of blue cornflowers, and further on, the sea. There's a stand that sells sandwiches and a road leading into town.

I stop by the stand. The man behind the cart is no man at all, an older boy with a bandage over his nose, narrow trimmed sunglasses, a spray bottle that he douses on his long black hair. The boy tells me it's to keep the heat off his head. I take my hat off and ask him for a spritz. It's ice cold and soaks nicely into my scalp.

"Rosbif ou dinde?" he asks.

"Turkey, lotta horseradish."

He nods and puts it together on rye.

"Enveloppé?"

"No just the napkin, thanks."

He hands it over in a napkin and I buy a fresca to go with it. I eat and walk the asphalt, the cool water in my hair slowly rising back to the scorch of the summer sun.

The road stretches the field of cornflower, blank and black between the blue pedals. It lines the field for a mile then dips below a hill where the town rests against the cliffs and the sea.

I walk forward, the lone station behind me, the train sounding steam and kicking off further into the country. In front of me, the shine of a motorcycle emerging fully from the hills, riding light and loud, hair golden and flowing back a metallic flag in the burning sun.

I lift my hand, raising the orange sweated glass into the air. I whistle out and the motorcycle slows and stops beside me. The engine idle, then dead, the road open, the wind on the flower, all silent and gone besides us two.

"Sasha!" she says.

"Hey, Pam."

"How'd it go? We missed you for Julie's labor you know."

"Yes, I'm sorry, I got the wire last night. How's the boy?"

Pam brings her hands out. "That'll be a big boy. For sure. How can anyone carry a thing like that! Let alone push it out."

"The initial size doesn't necessarily mean he'll grow big," I say.

"Yes, but her husband's quite the brute isn't he?"

I take a drink of fresca and point behind me toward the station with my half eaten sandwich.

"You headed out? You just missed the train."

She leans back on the bike, crossing her arms on her chest.

"Yes, I've got a list from Ruby and August. Then, Julie was saying that the baby might need a hat for the summer." There's an apple box tied off to the back of the motorcycle. "I told her, 'Julie, the little tike won't care if he gets a bit rosy on the cheeks.' She says, 'but he's so pale he'll burn up first day on the water.' 'Gosh, Julie,' I say, 'you can't bring the poor tike on the boat this soon after being born.' 'He needs to get his sea legs right away or he'll be sick all the time when he's older. Sammy's father didn't bring him on the boat til he was fourteen and you know how sick he gets, especially near the end of the season.' Well at this point I'd forgotten all about the dumb little hat and she's already handing me cash to go pick one up while I'm in the city and so here I am."

"I think the hat will be a good idea," I say.

"I'm sure it will, but where you buy hats for babies, I have no clue."

I give her a rough address for a store I think might have one and then we continue on our ways. Later on I turn to her silver motorcycle propped up against the station's platform, then it all falls away as I head down the hill into town.